television and the Internet, from Israel/Palestine and Iraq, convinced many Muslims that the USA was an enemy, not an ally. The continuing crisis in Israel/Palestine and the crippling effect of sanctions on Iraq (see page 133) ensured a steady stream of recruits to al-Qaida.

Al-Qaida targets the USA

Key question
What targets did al-Qaida select for bombing?

The leaders of al-Qaida did not set out to build a mass protest movement or to fight elections. Instead, they relied on a small number of activists, loosely connected to each other, who often had little contact with the organisation's leaders so that it was difficult for the security services to penetrate them. As the twentieth century drew to a close, al-Qaida leaders had in their sights the one country that dominated the Middle East. Even 10 years after the end of the Gulf War to liberate Kuwait, the USA still had 25,000 troops in the region, 10,000 of them in Saudi Arabia and Kuwait. The Americans had two aircraft carriers in the Gulf, together with 15 warships and 350 fighter jets. They had yet more troops and planes on a huge military base in Turkey and they supplied billions of dollars' worth of military aid and weapons to Israel, Egypt, Turkey, Saudi Arabia and the smaller Gulf states. In the eyes of many living in the Middle East, it seemed like a deliberate design to dominate the Arab and Muslim world.

In the late 1990s, members of al-Qaida embarked on a number of spectacular attacks on US targets:

- In 1996, a truck bomb targeted a US military barracks in Saudi Arabia, killing or injuring nearly 400 Americans.
- In 1998, 19 suicide 'martyrs' bombed the US embassies in Kenya and Tanzania, killing 12 American diplomats and 200 Africans.
- In 2000, a boat packed with explosives rammed the side of the USS *Cole*, a destroyer, off the coast of Yemen, killing 17 American sailors.

'9/11': The attack on the World Trade Center in New York 2001

Key question
What was the impact of '9/11'?

Key date
'9/11' attacks on New York and Washington: September 2001

On 11 September 2001, 19 men hijacked four US passenger planes and flew two of them into the twin towers of the World Trade Center in New York and one into the Pentagon, the US defence centre, in Washington DC. A fourth plane crashed in Pennsylvania. Over 3000 people were killed. The majority of Muslims were appalled. The Koran teaches that the only just war is a war of self-defence. But Osama Bin Laden and his followers claimed (and still do) that Muslims *were* under attack – in Arabia, in Iraq, in Palestine – and that the US supported corrupt and oppressive governments such as that of Saudi Arabia, from where most of the '9/11' bombers originated. Nevertheless, although millions of Arabs felt angry and bitter after years of humiliation by the West, the methods of '9/11' caused revulsion. Even the Iranian President, who was no friend of the USA, condemned what he saw as the bombers' un-Islamic methods.